

I'm so angry, I made this sign

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‘I’m so angry, I made this sign’ Public Installation by Vaishali & Sanjeev at Marina Beach, Chennai

In an age where placards have become both tools of resistance and icons of public sentiment, the collaborative installation ‘I’m so angry, I made this sign’ by Vaishali & Sanjeev stakes a bold claim, both as art and as a protest. Set against the expansive, turbulent backdrop of Marina Beach in Chennai, this monumental work uses the charged language of dissent to engage the public in a confrontation with collective emotion, political disillusionment, and the theatre of protest itself.

The installation stretches across 1.5 kilometres of the beachfront with a 150 meter breadth, incorporating thousands of paper flags, bamboo scaffolding, terracotta clay, and phosphorescent paints. At its visual core is a 50 x 20 meter scaffolded structure spelling out the eponymous phrase — ‘I’m so angry, I made this sign’ — in luminous ceramic letters. By day, the black flags inscribed with bright red and green fluorescent lettering flutter fiercely in the sea breeze; by night, they glow like embers of long-suppressed voices.

Originating from a protest placard spotted during the Occupy Wall Street movement in New York in 2011, the phrase chosen by the artists has since become emblematic of spontaneous political expression — both sincere and absurd. It’s a line that is at once self-aware and deeply emotive - a confession, an action, and an artwork all in one. In this installation, it becomes a collective chorus, reverberating across a sea of miniature signs planted in the sand like a silent, stubborn army.

The choice of materials reinforces the installation’s ephemeral yet charged presence. Paper flags tremble vulnerably in the wind, suggesting both fragility and persistence. The bamboo scaffolding - rustic, makeshift, and inherently unstable, mirrors the improvisational nature of many grassroots protests. Terracotta elements draw on indigenous crafts and local labour, grounding the work in a specific geography even as it addresses global discontent. The phosphorescent colours glow in the dark like latent rage, always present, always waiting.

Vaishali & Sanjeev’s use of repetition - thousands of flags with the same phrase, turns a singular emotion into a spectacle of plurality. What might have started as a lone individual’s frustration now reads as a mass phenomenon. The installation resists any didacticism. Instead, it revels in irony, emotion, and contradiction. There is anger, but it is poetic. There is protest, but it is also deeply introspective.

What elevates this installation from an act of public signage to a conceptual artwork is its layered commentary. The flags do not just signify outrage, they satirize its commodification. In an era when anger is quickly aestheticized, photographed, and disseminated across social media, the sign becomes not just a political statement but also a performance, a prop, a meme. This awareness is built into the work.

There is also a deliberate invocation of theorist Slavoj Žižek’s critique of performative protest. Žižek once warned against the fetish of immediate direct democracy, the idea that occupying space and expressing dissent, however cathartic, might still play into the hands of the very systems it seeks to challenge. Vaishali & Sanjeev seem to engage with this tension. Their work neither fully endorses nor fully mocks the act of protest; instead, it asks us to examine the form, its aesthetics, its motives, and its legacy.

The Marina Beach too is not just a site — it is a collaborator. The natural sounds of the wind and waves, amplified by the rustling of thousands of flags, create an auditory layer that is at once soothing and unsettling. The murmuring flicker of paper in the wind resembles the noise of a restless crowd. This organic soundscape reinforces the installation’s dynamic quality. It is not static art — it moves, it breathes, it seethes.

Installed as part of the Chennai Art Show, curated by Koumudi Patil, the work also highlights how contemporary art is reclaiming public space in India. By moving beyond gallery walls, Vaishali & Sanjeev’s installation invites passers-by, beachgoers, and locals into an immersive, participatory engagement. It is a quiet confrontation - not loud or disruptive, but insistent, like a protest that never ends.

In daylight, the black and neon flags create a surreal landscape, appearing almost digital in their palette. At night, the installation morphs into a glowing constellation, like a mass dream or a subconscious uprising. Seen from afar, the scattered signs recall cemeteries or war memorials, a visual evocation of casualties of thought, lost causes, or silenced voices. Yet there is hope, too. Each sign is a record of presence, a trace of someone’s emotion made visible, tangible, unignorable.

Ultimately, “I am so angry, I made this sign” is not about a single issue - it is about the act of being moved enough to act. It questions whether anger is enough, whether a sign is enough, whether repetition is enough. But it never denies the dignity in trying.

As the artists channel a common protest slogan into a new cultural and political context, their work reminds us that anger, like art, refuses containment. It must find a form, however fleeting, however fragile, and sometimes that form is a sign on a stick, fluttering against the vastness of sky and sea.....



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Medium: Paper flags, bamboo scaffolding, terracotta clay, and phosphorescent colours, 1.5 kilometres long spread on Marina Beach of Chennai.

Year: 2012